

I CANNOT REMEMBER MY MOTHER

Class 9 English – Kaveri | Poem 4 | Rabindranath Tagore

Detailed Poetry Solutions + Appreciation + Exam Practice

This pack covers the current Kaveri poem exercises: Reflect and Respond, Reading for Appreciation, Check Your Understanding, Critical Reflection, Vocabulary in Context, Listening, Speaking, Writing and Learning Beyond the Text.

The poem appears in the current Kaveri Unit 4 sequence and the textbook exercise wording was verified from the current chapter text. ■cite■turn3view1■turn3view2■

1. POEM INFORMATION

Item	Details
Title	I Cannot Remember My Mother
Poet	Rabindranath Tagore
Form	Short lyric / memory poem
Structure	Three compact stanzas connected by a repeated refrain
Key senses	Hearing, smell, sight
Important symbols	Humming tune, shiuli flowers, temple service, distant sky
Central concern	The mother is not directly remembered, yet her presence survives through sensory and emotional memory

2. STANZA-WISE EXPLANATION

Stanza 1 – The remembered tune

The speaker says he cannot remember his mother directly. Yet while he is playing, a tune seems to hover over his playthings. It is the tune of a song his mother used to hum while rocking his cradle. Thus, hearing becomes the doorway to memory. The speaker cannot recall the mother's physical presence clearly, but he retains the emotional trace of her lullaby.

Stanza 2 – The fragrance of shiuli

On an early autumn morning, the smell of shiuli flowers floats in the air. The fragrance of the temple's morning service comes to the speaker as the scent of his mother. Smell therefore brings back the feeling of the mother. The memory is indirect, but emotionally powerful.

Stanza 3 – The mother's gaze in the sky

When the speaker looks from his bedroom window into the distant blue sky, he feels that the stillness of his mother's gaze has spread across the sky. Sight now becomes the medium of remembrance. The sky symbolically expands the mother's loving presence beyond physical boundaries.

3. IMPORTANT WORDS & MEANINGS

Word / phrase	Meaning
midst	middle
hover	linger or remain nearby
playthings	toys
hum	sing softly with closed lips
cradle	a small bed used for a baby
shiuli	a fragrant autumn flower, also known as coral jasmine / parijat
scent	smell or fragrance
morning service	rituals or prayers conducted in a temple
gaze	a steady look
stillness	complete calm or lack of movement
distant	far away

4. POETIC DEVICES

Device	Example / feature	Effect
Refrain	"I cannot remember my mother"	Creates emotional unity and emphasizes the paradox of forgetting yet remembering
Imagery	tune, playthings, shiuli fragrance, temple service, blue sky	Appeals to hearing, smell and sight, making memory vivid.
Symbolism	shiuli, tune, sky	Objects of nature and sound become symbols of maternal presence.
Metaphor / imaginative comparison	mother's gaze has "spread all over the sky"	Transforms a private memory into a vast visual image.
Personification / animation	tune seems to "hover"	Makes the remembered music feel like a living presence.
Alliteration	repeated initial sounds in selected phrases	Adds musicality and softness to the poem.

5. CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING – COMPLETE SOLUTIONS

I. Fill in the blanks

Stanza	Answer
1.1	The poet remembers his mother while he plays / is playing .
1.2	He remembers the tune but not the mother .
Setting	Indoor
2.1	He remembers his mother in the autumn season.
2.2	He remembers her by the smell of shiuli flowers .
Setting	Outdoor
3.1	He feels that his mother gazes at him from the sky .
Setting	Indoor (the speaker is looking from his bedroom window)

II. Sensory references

Stanza	Textual reference	Sense
1	the tune of some song that she used to hum while rocking my cradle	Auditory / hearing
2	the smell of the shiuli flowers floats in the air	Olfactory / smell
3	the blue of the distant sky / mother's gaze on my face	Visual / sight

III. Appreciation questions

- Two examples of alliteration: "**mother's ... midst**" / "**my ... mother**" can be identified as examples of repeated initial sounds depending on the line grouping. The poem's strongest musical effect, however, comes from repetition and sound patterns rather than a fixed rhyme scheme.
- Onomatopoeia: The poem itself has no strong conventional onomatopoeic word such as 'buzz' or 'hiss'. The soft auditory effect comes mainly through 'hum' and the imagined hovering tune.
- The poem uses imagery extensively because it makes the reader hear the mother's tune, smell the shiuli and temple fragrance, and see the distant blue sky. These sensory pictures convert memory into an immediate experience.
- Although there is no fixed rhyme scheme, the poem remains enjoyable because of its musical rhythm, repetition, sensory imagery and gentle emotional movement.
- The tone is nostalgic, tender and serene, with an undertone of loss. The speaker cannot consciously recall his mother, yet ordinary sensory experiences repeatedly bring her presence back.

6. The title establishes a mood of absence and loss. As the poem develops, the title becomes almost paradoxical because each stanza actually shows another way in which the mother is remembered.
7. The refrain is repeated to emphasize the gap between conscious memory and emotional memory. The speaker says he cannot remember her, but every stanza gives evidence that her presence survives.
8. The symbols are the humming tune (maternal care and childhood), shiuli flowers and temple fragrance (sensory memory and sacred association), and the sky (the vast, enduring presence of the mother's gaze).

6. CRITICAL REFLECTION – EXTRACT 1

"I cannot remember my mother / only sometimes in the midst of my play / a tune seems to hover over my playthings..."

- i) The poet is reminded of his mother during his **playtime / play**.
- ii) Correct answer: **C. It activates memories of the mother.**
- iii) The hovering tune acts as a bridge between the speaker's present playtime and his childhood memory of his mother's lullaby. It restores an emotional connection without restoring a complete visual memory.
- iv) True. The speaker says the tune appears 'only sometimes' during his play.
- v) He feels her presence through the tune she used to hum while rocking his cradle. The sound has survived even though direct memory of her has faded.

7. CRITICAL REFLECTION – EXTRACT 2

"I feel that the stillness of my mother's gaze on my face has spread all over the sky."

- i) Correct answer: **B. The sky is a symbolic extension of the mother's presence.**
- ii) Correct answer: **D. A sense of serenity.**
- iii) True. The poet imagines the mother's gaze as something that has visually and emotionally spread across the sky.
- iv) The comparison makes the mother's presence seem vast, calm and enduring. The sky becomes a visual symbol through which the speaker experiences her gaze.
- v) The tone is **nostalgic and serene** because the speaker recalls his mother through the calm, expansive image of the distant sky.

8. CRITICAL REFLECTION – LONGER ANSWERS

Q1. What is the emotional impact of the refrain 'I cannot remember my mother'?

The refrain creates a feeling of loss, tenderness and irony. The speaker repeatedly says that he cannot remember his mother, yet every stanza reveals a sensory trace of her presence. Therefore, the refrain suggests that conscious memory may fade while love remains deeply embedded in the person.

Q2. Interpret the connection between the mother and (i) shiuli flowers and (ii) humming tune.

(i) The fragrance of shiuli and the temple's morning service evokes the mother's scent and presence. (ii) The humming tune recalls the mother rocking the speaker's cradle. Both are sensory triggers that preserve maternal memory.

Q3. What role does nature play in the poet's description of his mother's memory?

Nature acts as a storehouse of memory. The fragrance of flowers and the vast blue sky allow the speaker to experience his mother indirectly. Nature transforms a personal memory into something universal and enduring.

Q4. What can be inferred about the poet's perception of the mother-child relationship?

The relationship is presented as deeply emotional and lasting. A mother's care becomes part of a child's inner world so deeply that even when direct memory is incomplete, sensory experiences continue to awaken her

presence.

9. VOCABULARY IN CONTEXT

I. Classify the sensory words

Visual	Auditory	Olfactory	Tactile
glowing, gloomy, crimson, vibrant, glistening, size	gigantic, deafening, squeaky, ear-splitting	fragrant, stinky, pungent, stale	rough, chilled, smooth, slimy, fluffy, hairy

II. Sarojini Naidu passage – answers

1. scarlet 2. scents 3. sweetness 4. shrill 5. perfumes 6. essence 7. flaming. Extra words: **sizzle** and **smooth**. ■cite■turn5search4■

III. Picture-matching guide

Match each phrase to the picture according to its dominant sensory association: music/drums → auditory; incense/fragrance → olfactory; flowers/blooming buds → olfactory; cradle/lullaby → auditory; colourful sky → visual; horizon/landscape → visual. The exact numbering should be written beneath the corresponding pictures in the textbook.

10. LISTEN AND RESPOND

Statement	Speaker
1. Precious memories by the seaside are not the same anymore.	Speaker (iv)
2. Grandfather’s encouragement influences me in moments of difficulty.	Speaker (i)
3. School days are a source of recollection to stay in touch.	Not needed
4. Childhood days are about freedom and ordinary pleasures in outdoor activities.	Speaker (ii)
5. Memories of school days include grandparents and funny tales.	Speaker (iii)
6. Parents urge us to be adventurous and discover nature but with limitations.	Not needed

The current solution references give the same matching and identify statements 3 and 6 as not required.

■cite■turn5search0■turn5search4■

11. SPEAKING ACTIVITY – MODEL RESPONSE

“During my childhood, one object I remember clearly is an old storybook that belonged to my grandfather. Its pages were slightly yellow and it had a distinctive paper smell. I used to sit beside him and listen while he read the stories aloud. Even today, seeing a similar book reminds me of those quiet evenings. The memory is meaningful because it connects reading with affection, family and the feeling of being cared for.”

12. WRITING TASK – DIARY ENTRY

17 September 2026, Thursday

9:00 p.m.

Dear Diary,

Today’s school trip to a hill station was unforgettable. The first thing I noticed was the cool breeze touching my face and the fresh fragrance of flowers and wet soil. The mountains looked blue in the distance, while the clouds moved slowly across the sky. I could hear birds, flowing water and the soft sound of leaves moving in the wind.

We walked along a narrow path and stopped near a small stream. I dipped my hands into the cold water and felt completely refreshed. The peaceful surroundings made me forget the noise and pressure of everyday life. I also realised how strongly sights, sounds and smells can stay in our memory.

Tonight, I feel grateful for the experience. I know that whenever I smell wet earth or hear a mountain stream, this day will return to me as a vivid memory.

13. LEARNING BEYOND THE TEXT – SHIULI FLOWER

Shiuli is also known as Parijat, Parijata and Harsingar. It is a fragrant flower associated with Indian traditions and ceremonial practices. It blooms at night and releases a sweet fragrance. ■cite■turn3view3■

Examples of other distinctive Indian flowers for research: Neelakurinji, lotus, night-blooming jasmine, Brahma Kamal and palash. Students can add location, appearance, fragrance, blooming season and cultural significance.

14. ADDITIONAL IMPORTANT QUESTIONS

Q1. How is the title of the poem paradoxical?

The speaker says he cannot remember his mother, yet the entire poem is about remembering her through a tune, fragrance and gaze. The title therefore expresses the difference between conscious visual memory and deeper emotional memory.

Q2. How do the three stanzas correspond to three senses?

Stanza 1 is auditory because of the humming tune; stanza 2 is olfactory because of the fragrance of shiuli and temple service; stanza 3 is visual because of the distant blue sky and the mother's imagined gaze.

Q3. Why is the sky an appropriate image for the mother's gaze?

The sky is vast, calm and seemingly limitless. By spreading the mother's gaze across it, the poet suggests that her loving presence has become larger than a physical memory and remains with him wherever he looks.

Q4. Why does the poem remain moving despite its simplicity?

Its language is simple but its emotional idea is profound. The poem shows that love can survive the fading of conscious memory. Familiar sensory experiences quietly reconnect the speaker with his mother.

15. MCQs – POEM PRACTICE

1. Who wrote 'I Cannot Remember My Mother'?

- A. Sarojini Naidu
- B. Rabindranath Tagore
- C. Thomas Hood
- D. William Wordsworth

Answer: B

2. What first reminds the speaker of his mother?

- A. A photograph
- B. A tune
- C. A letter
- D. A flower

Answer: B

3. The mother used to hum while—

- A. cooking
- B. walking
- C. rocking the cradle
- D. praying

Answer: C

4. Which flower is mentioned?

- A. Rose
- B. Lotus
- C. Shiuli
- D. Lily

Answer: C

5. The shiuli reference mainly appeals to—

- A. smell
- B. taste
- C. touch
- D. hearing

Answer: A

6. In the third stanza, the speaker looks at—

- A. a river
- B. the blue distant sky
- C. a mountain
- D. a garden

Answer: B

7. The repeated line is called a—

- A. couplet
- B. refrain
- C. sonnet
- D. pun

Answer: B

8. The poem's tone is mainly—

- A. comic
- B. nostalgic and serene
- C. angry
- D. adventurous

Answer: B

9. The sky symbolises—

- A. danger
- B. the mother's enduring presence
- C. school
- D. childhood games

Answer: B

10. The poem connects memory strongly with—

- A. sensory experiences
- B. examinations
- C. travel
- D. money

Answer: A

11. 'Hover' means—

- A. disappear
- B. remain nearby
- C. fall quickly
- D. shine brightly

Answer: B

12. The dominant literary technique in the poem's structure is—

- A. refrain and imagery
- B. satire
- C. dramatic dialogue
- D. rhyme

Answer: A

13. The mother's gaze is described as—

- A. noisy
- B. still
- C. angry
- D. hurried

Answer: B

14. The poem has—

- A. a fixed rhyme scheme
- B. no fixed rhyme scheme
- C. a heroic couplet
- D. a sonnet form

Answer: B

15. The deepest message is that—

- A. memory is always exact
- B. emotional bonds can survive fading conscious memory
- C. nature destroys memories
- D. childhood should be forgotten

Answer: B

16. EXAM-READY ANSWER-WRITING TIPS

- For a 2-mark poetry answer, identify the image/device and explain its effect in one or two sentences.
- For a 3–4 mark answer, connect the sensory image to the speaker's memory and emotion.
- For extract questions, answer from the given lines first, then add the poem's broader context.
- Remember the three sensory anchors: **tune** → **hearing**; **shiuli** → **smell**; **sky/gaze** → **sight**.

Textbook exercise sequence and key answers were cross-checked against current 2026 Kaveri solution references and the chapter text. ■cite■turn3view1■turn5search4■